

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

21 January 2014

To an individual Bahá'í

¹ Dear Bahá'í Friend,

² The Universal House of Justice has received your email letter ... in which you pose thoughtful and probing questions about the application of the principles of the oneness of mankind and the equality of men and women, as well as the promotion of the Bahá'í teachings in the wider society.... We have been asked to convey the following.

³ Among your questions is how the roles of men and women should be defined and reinforced when applying Bahá'í principles in current and future society. In its Riḍván 2012 message, the House of Justice indicated that it is not possible today to glimpse “anything but an intimation, distant and indistinct, of the future society to which the Revelation of Bahá'u'lláh is destined to give rise”, and it observed that none should “suppose that the civilization towards which the divine teachings impel humankind will follow merely from adjustments to the present order.” Rather, ‘Abdu’l-Bahá has stated that “‘among the results of the manifestation of spiritual forces will be that the human world will adapt itself to a new social form’”. It is impossible at present to foresee how the principles of the Faith will be applied as the process of organic change unfolds under the influence of the Divine Plan. However, we may, through personal daily study and through acts of service to the Faith and to one’s fellow man and by resolving questions through prayerful reflection and sincere consultation, come to a better understanding of how to apply the teachings in our daily lives and contribute to the advancement of society—including matters pertaining to gender equality.

⁴ As to your question of how the Bahá'í approach to promoting the equality of men and women differs from that taken by others, the distinction is reflected in our principles and approach. The main concern and contribution of the followers of Bahá'u'lláh is the spiritual transformation of human society, with full confidence that by this means they are making a most valuable and most fundamental contribution to the betterment of the world and the rectification of its many problems. Not only is the Bahá'í perspective unique, so too are the methods used by the believers to achieve their objectives. Unity and cooperation are important values that should be the watchwords for activities in which the believers engage. The injunction to avoid participation in political controversies, identification with political pursuits, or involvement in partisan political affairs leaves a wide range of possible activities open to Bahá'ís for participation with other groups in an effort to promote measures in accord with Bahá'í principles. The Bahá'í Faith directs its attention principally to the promotion of attitudinal change consequent to acceptance of the claim of Bahá'u'lláh, and the friends may be confident that the transformation of attitudes and values will, in due course, yield its fruit in measures that will resolve the problems with which humanity is now burdened.

5 The Bahá'í approach to the questions you have raised is one which will be worked out over time through patient and persistent effort and by the process of learning in which the Bahá'í community is engaged. This process will be augmented by research and discussion and by attempts to correlate the teachings with modern thought, including the identification of similarities and distinctions between the teachings and contemporary social constructs. Involvement in the discourses of society by believers in various social spaces will sharpen the insights gained. Ongoing study of the teachings and systematic endeavour to translate Bahá'í principles into action by engaging in the processes of community building, education of children and youth, and social action will assist in refining our grasp of Bahá'u'lláh's intention for humanity in all areas of life. In the years ahead, the ability of the Bahá'í community to contribute to thought-shaping social change will increase, and answers to questions that appear to be unsolvable today will become apparent through a process of organic change, rather than as a result of imposing particular perspectives.

6 In this regard, it may be helpful to reflect upon the extent and complex nature of the work that lies ahead. A particular characteristic of the modern world is the wide divergence of thoughts and extreme positions on almost any subject—a characteristic which regrettably sometimes leads to contention and even conflict. Moreover, the search for solutions can be blocked by intractable ideological positions. Discussion of the subject of the equality of men and women in the wider society is, alas, not immune from these general conditions. While this should not in itself deter Bahá'ís from entering a given discourse, it does demand from them a greater level of detachment and a keener awareness so as not to take on the attitudes of contention that the adoption of extreme positions necessarily entails. Humility, too, is required since, for the most part, the work of correlating the Bahá'í teachings with perspectives found in the wider society has not yet been carried out in a detailed way and is still in its early stages. Thus, points of agreement and points of distinction with various strands of thought on any given theme are not yet fully explored. As Bahá'ís continue to engage in this effort, deeper levels of insight will undoubtedly emerge. And in this particular area of enquiry—the equality of men and women—as in any other area where the believers hope to participate in a discourse with other individuals and agencies that are earnestly seeking answers to the challenges facing humanity, systematic effort, patience and encouragement in allowing the expression of diverse views as a contribution to the search for truth, fair-minded and dispassionate consultation, as well as reflection on experience will be required over time so that Bahá'ís can learn and gradually become ever more effective in contributing to understanding and progress in the wider society. In this process, mistakes will inevitably be made, and the bonds of love and unity among the believers will be essential in enabling them to persevere until Bahá'u'lláh's intended aim for humanity is realized in the centuries ahead.

7 With respect to your question about the involvement of Bahá'ís in social action and the discourses of society, it is hoped that you have had an opportunity to study the letter dated 2 March 2013 from the House of Justice to the Bahá'ís of Iran. The letter was sent to all National Spiritual Assemblies and discusses, within the context of the needs and conditions of contemporary society, the Bahá'í perspective on participation in social change while avoiding involvement in partisan political activity. If you have specific questions about your participation in public forums and engagement in social action, you are encouraged to turn to your National Assembly, as circumstances vary from country to country and place to place, and that body is in the best position to offer you guidance and advice.

⁸ Passages from the compilation titled “Women”, prepared by the Research Department, shed light on many of the questions you have raised. We have enclosed for your study the English translation of a letter dated 20 June 2008 written by the House of Justice to the Bahá’ís of Iran on the topic of the equality of men and women....

⁹ Your desire to understand more deeply the principle of the equality of men and women and its implications is commendable, and it is hoped that your discerning reflections on the guidance offered above will enable you to contribute to the relevant public discourse both within and outside the Bahá’í community. May you be blessed and confirmed in your efforts to advance the exploration of these issues and to serve the Cause and humanity.

With loving Bahá’í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]